



The Stone That Ice Would Not Carry

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The following examines how researchers traced the origin of Stonehenge's central Altar Stone and weighed whether ice or human hands carried it the length of Britain.

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 Ice is patient. People are deliberate. The flat slab at the heart of Stonehenge, the one called the Altar Stone, asks which of those two moved it, and a 2026 study says the answer is the second.

2 **Begin with the rock itself** [Imagery]. It is sandstone, about sixteen feet long, more than thirteen thousand pounds, six tonnes of single stone laid flat where the great uprights meet. For years its birthplace was put somewhere in Wales, near the smaller bluestones around it. The new work moves it much farther. The grains in it match the Orcadian Basin, the old sandstone country of northeast Scotland, more than four hundred and fifty miles from Salisbury Plain. The team behind the finding worked across several institutions, with Curtin University in Australia and Sheffield Hallam, Sheffield, Bristol, and Wessex Archaeology in Britain.

3 **How they fixed the source is its own kind of patience: they read the ages locked inside individual mineral grains, the tiny clocks a rock keeps from the day it formed, and matched that signature against the rock of the far north** [Metaphor]. The match held. A slab quarried near the top of the island had ended up at the bottom of it, set among stones added to the monument somewhere between roughly 2620 and 2480 B.C.E.

4 Then the harder question. A stone can travel without anyone choosing to move it. Glaciers drag boulders for hundreds of miles and drop them where the ice dies, far from where they began, and for a six-tonne block that is no small possibility. So the researchers built a model of where the old ice sheets flowed. The ice, they found, could plausibly have carried rock as far as Dogger Bank, the drowned land now under the North Sea between Britain and the continent. It does not reach southern England. The glaciers stop short of Stonehenge.

5 **Which leaves the gap to be closed by hands** [Antithesis]. If the ice could not deliver the stone, then people did: hundreds of kilometres of it, over land and water, by what the work describes as coordinated effort across communities [Cumulative and periodic sentences]. Remy Veness, the glaciologist who ran the ice-flow modelling, is the one who drew that line where the ice gives out. Anthony Clarke, a co-lead author, put the conclusion plainly. "Rather than being carried naturally by ice, the evidence points to a deliberate, carefully planned movement across a challenging and varied landscape." [Logos]

6 **What that movement actually looked like, the study does not claim to know. The route is unrecovered. The method, whether sledge or raft or some long relay of both, is not in the rock. The grains can name the quarry and the ice can be ruled out, and still the four hundred and fifty miles in between stay a blank the**

science has narrowed but not filled [Asyndeton]. A people who left no writing moved a stone the length of their island and told no one how, and the henge keeps that part to itself.

Devices, and why they are here:

Imagery (paragraph 2): “Begin with the rock itself”

Opens the second paragraph on the physical stone in concrete, measurable terms (length, weight, sandstone laid flat) so the scale registers through sense and fact rather than through any claim that it is impressive.

Metaphor (paragraph 3): “How they fixed the source is its own kind of patience: they read the ages locked inside individual mineral grains, the tiny clocks a rock keeps from the day it formed, and matched that signature against the rock of the far north”

Calls the mineral grains tiny clocks the rock keeps, making an unfamiliar dating method graspable by mapping it onto a familiar timekeeping image without overstating it.

Antithesis (paragraph 5): “Which leaves the gap to be closed by hands”

Sets ice against hands in balanced opposition, naming the single tension the whole piece runs on: natural transport versus deliberate human movement.

Cumulative and periodic sentences (paragraph 5): “If the ice could not deliver the stone, then people did: hundreds of kilometres of it, over land and water, by what the work describes as coordinated effort across communities”

Front-loads a conditional, then lets the consequence accumulate across the distance and the means, so the sentence enacts the long human haul it describes.

Logos (paragraph 5): ““Rather than being carried naturally by ice, the evidence points to a deliberate, carefully planned movement across a challenging and varied landscape.””

Lands the lead researcher’s verbatim conclusion as the reasoned inference the evidence forces, letting the quoted reasoning carry authority rather than the writer asserting it.

Asyndeton (paragraph 6): “The grains can name the quarry and the ice can be ruled out, and still the four hundred and fifty miles in between stay a blank the science has narrowed but not filled”

Strings the certainties together with commas and no closing conjunction so the known facts pile up fast against the one thing still unknown, leaving the gap exposed.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the fourth paragraph, the writer introduces the possibility that glaciers moved the stone primarily in order to
 - A) show that the ice-sheet model was the least reliable part of the research
 - B) argue that the earlier Welsh-origin theory was the more likely account
 - C) suggest that the stone's weight made any human transport impossible
 - D) raise and then rule out a natural explanation before crediting human effort
2. In context, the final sentence of the last paragraph ("A people who left no writing... keeps that part to itself") most contributes to the passage's tone of
 - A) mounting alarm at a discovery that unsettles settled history
 - B) measured wonder held in check by candor about what is unknown
 - C) brisk confidence that the central mystery has been solved
 - D) gentle irony at the expense of the researchers' overreach

Multiple choice answer key:

1. **Answer D.** The paragraph builds the glacier scenario in good faith (a six-tonne block is no small possibility, the ice could reach Dogger Bank) and then states the ice stops short of Stonehenge, so the move sets up a natural explanation only to eliminate it and hand the work to people. The Welsh-origin option misreads the third paragraph, where Wales is the discarded source of the rock, not a transport theory the writer endorses. The least-reliable-model option inverts the text, which treats the ice model as the decisive tool that closes the natural route. The impossibility option overstates the passage, which concludes people did move it, not that they could not.
2. **Answer B.** The sentence pairs a genuinely striking image (a stone hauled the length of an island by people who left no record) with an admission that the how stays hidden, which sustains the piece's restrained admiration alongside its honesty about the blank that remains. The alarm option misreads the calm, unhurried handling for distress the text never shows. The irony option fails because the writer credits the researchers' method rather than mocking it; the limit named is in the evidence, not in their reach. The confidence option contradicts the paragraph, which explicitly says the route and method are not known.

Discussion questions:

1. The piece spends a full paragraph building the case that glaciers could have moved the stone before setting that case aside. How does granting the natural explanation real weight change the force of the conclusion that people moved it?
2. The writer ends not on the discovery but on what remains unknown: the route and the method. What does closing on an admitted limit, rather than on the achievement, do to how you read the researchers' authority?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. The glacier paragraph works as a genuine concession rather than a straw target. By granting that ice drags boulders for hundreds of miles and could plausibly reach Dogger Bank, the writer makes the natural explanation strong enough to take seriously, so that ruling it out with the ice-flow model carries weight. The human conclusion then arrives as something the evidence forces ('If the ice could not deliver the stone, then people did'), not as a romantic assumption. Had the writer dismissed glaciers in a line, the deliberate-movement claim would read as a guess dressed up as a finding.
2. Closing on the unknown deepens the researchers' authority rather than undercutting it. The piece is careful to separate what the grains can establish (the Scottish quarry) and what the ice model can establish (that glaciers stop short) from what neither can recover (the actual route and means). By naming that blank plainly, the writer signals that the science claims only what it can support. The final image, a stone moved the length of an island by a people who left no record of how, lets the wonder stand on accurate limits instead of overreach, which is what makes the restraint persuasive.

Writing prompt (Q2 rhetorical analysis):

The following passage examines how researchers traced the origin of Stonehenge's Altar Stone and weighed whether ice or human effort carried it across Britain. Read the passage carefully. Then, in a well-written essay, analyze the rhetorical choices the writer makes to convey an attitude toward both what the research has established and what remains unknown.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- That the study recovered the route or method by which the stone was moved. The passage states the opposite: the Scottish source is fixed and glacier transport is ruled out, but the actual path and means (sledge, raft, relay) remain unknown.
- That ruling out glaciers proves a single grand organized expedition. The text supports only that people moved the stone hundreds of kilometres through coordinated effort across communities; it does not describe one journey, one crew, or one technique.
- That the Altar Stone was always known to come from Scotland. The piece notes its origin had for years been placed in Wales near the bluestones, and the new grain-matching work is what relocated the source to the far north.

AP exam alignment:

Targets the four AP English Language reading skills across two items: the first MCQ tests Reasoning and Organization (Skill Category 5) by asking what the concede-then-eliminate move in the fourth paragraph accomplishes in the line of reasoning; the second tests Style (Skill Category 7) by asking how the closing sentence shapes tone. The two discussion questions extend Claims and Evidence (the function of a real concession) and Rhetorical Situation (how an admitted limit positions the writer's authority). The writing task is a Q2 rhetorical analysis, the fitting FRQ for an observational Long Look passage that renders and weighs evidence without arguing a contestable thesis, so a Q3 argument prompt is deliberately not used.